THE ARMY PUSHES BACK

THE BANGLADESH ARMY CHIEF'S CALL FOR AN EARLY ELECTION SPARKS FRESH SPECULATION ON THE FATE OF THE PROF. MUHAMMAD YUNUS-HEADED INTERIM GOVERNMENT

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

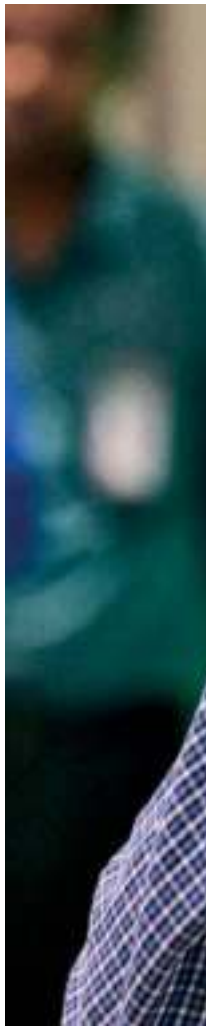
When General Waker-uz-Zaman, chief of the Bangladesh army, addressed a durbar at Senaprangan, the army central auditorium in Dhaka, on May 21, speculation was rife that he might call for the ouster of the country's 'Chief Advisor' Muhammad Yunus. But that didn't happen. Instead, Gen. Zaman reportedly told senior officers that he hoped that by "January 1, 2026, Bangladesh will be governed by a new elected government". The statement, interpreted as a gentle ultimatum rather than a threat, did not sit well with Yunus's interim government.

By the evening of the next day, the pressure showed. Yunus reached out to former cabinet colleague Nahid Islam, one of the faces of the July uprising last year and convenor of the National Citizen Party (NCP), and reportedly expressed a desire to step down. Islam, of course, dissuaded him. Sources in the NCP, which was born out of the student-led protests that ousted the Awami League regime last year, claim that Islam opened unofficial discussions with the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) and the Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami to defuse the situation. On May 24, Yunus convened a cabinet meeting to address the growing tensions between his administration, the army and political parties, followed by meetings with BNP and Jamaat leaders. Later, Yunus's press secretary Shafiqul Alam sought to calm the waters. "All political parties have expressed their faith in Yunus," he said. "He is a man of his word. Between December and June 30 (2026), elections will be held. Dr Yunus will not remain [in power] after June 30."

It did little to clear the air. The BNP was already on record demanding an election by December. At the meeting with Yunus, party leaders had reiterated this position and also demanded the removal of three key figures in his administration: National Security Advisor Khalilur Rahman, and advisors Asif Mahmud Bhuyian and Mahfuj Alam. Rahman, in particular, has been in the thick of it of late, facing allegations of holding US citizenship, and rumours that he's out to depose Gen. Zaman—all of which he has denied. As for Bhuyian and Alam, both former student activists-turned-advisors, the BNP has long viewed them as conduits between the government and the NCP.

There is also resentment over the interim government's 'reinstatement' of some Awami League beneficiaries. These individuals, accused of acts of violence and corruption during the Sheikh Hasina regime, were to face inquiry or removal. Instead, their re-entry into the administration has invited accusations of betrayal from activists who had helped bring down the old order. That said, the Awami League itself has now been banned, under the Anti-Terrorism Act.

This disenchantment is mirrored within the civil administration and business community too. Among the many sources of frustration is the Yunus government's reform proposal, targeting the National Board of Revenue (NBR). The plan, aimed at overhauling tax assessment, auditing and compliance mechanisms, has met with fierce resistance from mid-level bureaucrats and the influential trade bodies. Business



▲ **COLD VIBES** Gen. Waker-uz-Zaman and Prof. Yunus at the latter's swearing in as 'Chief Advisor' on Aug. 8, '24